4 How do we make decisions?

# Choose how to decide

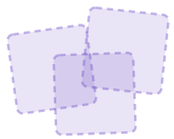


Write the decisions that keep coming back, one per post-it, and agree on one. Pick one of the twelve ways to make it, try it, then look back.

**Whole team · 40 min**

## Decisions we make again and again

Circle the one that matters most.



## Twelve ways to decide

**Narrow down options**

- [ ] **Dot voting** A long list of ideas needs a shortlist, fast.
- [ ] **Multi-voting** One round of votes is too scattered to show a favourite.
- [ ] **Scoring matrix** Every option has its own trade-offs.

**Decide quickly**

- [ ] **Majority vote** There are two options and either would work.
- [ ] **Plurality** There are several options and no time for more rounds.
- [ ] **Authority** One person is accountable for the outcome.

**Bring everyone along**

- [ ] **Fist to five** People seem to agree, but you can't tell if they really do.
- [ ] **Consensus** Everyone needs to support the decision to carry it out.
- [ ] **Consent** You need to move on, even if it isn't everyone's first choice.

**Settle who has the final say**

- [ ] **Supermajority** A big decision needs more than a narrow win.
- [ ] **Unanimity** Every person must actively agree before you move.
- [ ] **Delegation** The whole team doesn't need to weigh in every time.

## We will try

This way, for this decision.

## How did it feel?

Keep it, or try another?



© Michael Heider · CC BY-NC-SA 4.0

# Twelve ways to decide

Choose the way before the discussion starts. Ask what this decision needs most: narrowing many options, speed, everyone on board, or a clear final say. Then pick one way from that group and write it on the canvas.

## Narrow down options

### Dot voting

**How it works:** Everyone places a few dots in one round. Then talk about the options at the top.

**Use it when:** A long list of ideas needs a shortlist, fast.

**Watch out:** Popular isn't always right. Discuss the top options before you decide.

### Multi-voting

**How it works:** Vote in rounds and drop the weakest option each time, until a shortlist remains.

**Use it when:** One round of votes is too scattered to show a favourite.

**Watch out:** It takes longer. Agree the number of rounds up front.

### Scoring matrix

**How it works:** Rate each option against three to five agreed criteria, then compare totals and trade-offs.

**Use it when:** Every option has its own trade-offs.

**Watch out:** Agree the criteria before scoring, or people choose criteria that fit their favourite.

## Decide quickly

### Majority vote

**How it works:** One vote each. The option with more than half of the votes wins.

**Use it when:** There are two options and either would work.

**Watch out:** The losing side may not commit. Only use it when both options are acceptable.

### Plurality

**How it works:** One vote each. The option with the most votes wins, even below half.

**Use it when:** There are several options and no time for more rounds.

**Watch out:** The winner may have less than half the room behind it.

### Authority

**How it works:** One person hears from the people affected, then decides and explains why.

**Use it when:** One person is accountable for the outcome.

**Watch out:** Say up front that one person decides, and explain the decision afterwards.

## Bring everyone along

### Fist to five

**How it works:** Everyone shows zero to five fingers at the same time. Ask the lowest: what would raise your score by one?

**Use it when:** People seem to agree, but you can't tell if they really do.

**Watch out:** Low scores need a conversation, not a new vote.

### Consensus

**How it works:** Share a proposal, listen to concerns, adapt it, and check that everyone can back it.

**Use it when:** Everyone needs to support the decision to carry it out.

**Watch out:** Slow, and the most cautious person can block. Save it for decisions everyone must carry.

### Consent

**How it works:** Ask for serious reasons not to try it. Resolve the valid objections, then go ahead.

**Use it when:** You need to move on, even if it isn't everyone's first choice.

**Watch out:** An objection needs a reason, a risk or harm, not just a preference.

## Settle who has the final say

### Supermajority

**How it works:** Agree a threshold, such as 75%, before voting. Go ahead only if you reach it.

**Use it when:** A big decision needs more than a narrow win.

**Watch out:** Set the threshold before the vote, never after.

### Unanimity

**How it works:** Each person gives a clear yes or no. A single no sends the proposal back.

**Use it when:** Every person must actively agree before you move.

**Watch out:** One person can stop everything. Use it rarely.

### Delegation

**How it works:** Choose who decides, and agree their mandate, limits and deadline.

**Use it when:** The whole team doesn't need to weigh in every time.

**Watch out:** Write the mandate down, and don't overrule the person afterwards.

Combine them: narrow down with dot voting, then decide by consent. Whatever you choose, agree who decides, who is asked first, and who is told afterwards.



© Michael Heider · CC BY-NC-SA 4.0